

SHORT FICTION · FANTASY

The Power Brigade

Episode One

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The sun dropped behind the imperial box and cut the great arena of the Central City in two, one half gold, one half shadow. Under the open sky, the stands had filled to the top. Down below, on the sand churned up by the trials, only the fighters remained. They gathered in the middle, each with a sword at the hip or some other weapon, and they waited.

From the railing of the box, nine long lances had been set out, angled over the sand, and from each hung a new banner, high enough for a man to pass beneath it without touching it. Eight of them were blue as the sky and stitched with silver. The ninth was different, the only cloth with a thread of gold along its edge, raised a little higher than the rest. The whole arena knew the rule: to pass beneath a banner meant you had been chosen.

Next to the imperial box, the Oracle stepped forward, or rather an incarnation of It, a mask over the face and a long robe, holding a scroll in its hands. It raised a hand, and the arena fell silent.

“We live our lives telling stories. Some stories are about history and mistakes. Other stories are about the things we believe of the world and the lies we take for truth. But from today a new

set of stories begins. The Oracle has seen that our future starts here, with the Power Brigade: an elite team, created by the Golden Empire and its allies, made to move fast and with full freedom. Their mission is to save our Realm from a great cataclysm that will meet us in the days to come. There are nine banners here today. Each banner stands for the highest devotion to the Brigade's mission. After these three days of trials, we have our answer."

Xener burned with impatience. He was a young man, strong, with hair red as fire, and the journey from his mountain village to here, the center of the world, still felt like a dream. Even the points he had gathered over the last days of trials amazed him, and he wondered whether he would really be chosen. He had done rather well, by his own reckoning.

The Oracle unrolled the scroll and called out, always with the same formula: the name, and the points gathered across all the trials.

"Yeru. One hundred and twenty points."

Yeru broke from the group in the middle and crossed the sand. Under the first lance he stopped for a moment, then passed beneath the banner, and the shadow of the cloth slid across his face for the length of a single step. On the other side he turned to face the arena and stood there, the first man of the Brigade.

The crowd threw his name back at him like a wave breaking against the stands.

Xener looked down and noticed his clothes were a little scorched from the trials. From this evening on he wanted only one thing, and he wanted it so badly he felt it lodged in his throat like a swallow held too long: to hear his name called. As for the cloth with the golden thread, he had assumed it was for the best of them all. He had kept himself from thinking any further. He had sworn he would not run when he heard his name. That he would walk beneath the banners slowly, like a man who knows the place is his.

“Yaleo. One hundred and ten points.”

The giant, a mountain of a man tattooed all over, yet with a friendly look on his face, crossed the sand and stooped to fit beneath the banner, and the wave of cheering matched his size. Then Tenoct. Then Berach. Then the two women fighters who not long ago had fought each other to the death, and were now sisters. Then the young half demon, whose name the crowd cheered more quietly.

Before the second to last name, the Oracle glanced briefly toward the imperial box. From the sand, no one noticed.

“Raad. Ninety points.”

The eighth wave of applause broke and drew back. On the scroll, under the Oracle's finger, there were still lines left. The finger came down no further. One banner remained. But the scroll had begun to roll itself shut.

The Oracle turned toward the Emperor. Xener did not understand: the next place could have been his. The silence stretched over the arena, stretched over him, and only when the crowd began to murmur, and the murmur turned, head after head, toward the imperial box, did he too understand that the sound was not coming. The Emperor had risen.

"The ninth banner," he said, and his voice had no need to shout, "will be carried by my son, prince Agam."

That was all. The crowd began to cheer loudly, though somehow more timidly.

In the box, the prince rose slowly: black hair at the crown, gone white at the sides, his face unmoving. To Xener, that indifference seemed the most insolent thing he had ever seen.

The crowd murmured again, but the murmur tired quickly and settled, the way things settle when no one can change them anymore. The Oracle drew the scroll to its chest and took a step forward, ready to close the ceremony. The prince started toward the edge of the box.

In the middle of the sand, Xener stood with his thoughts spinning in his head, faster and faster: the lines still left on the scroll, his name uncalled, the cloth with the golden thread. He wanted to keep quiet. He held his mouth shut for exactly as long as a man holds his breath under water.

“I object!”

He heard his own voice before he understood that he was the one who had shouted. After that, things became very simple.

Later he did not remember deciding anything. He remembered the sand under his feet. The step. Another step. The line of fighters parting to make way. The guards jerking out from under the box and the Emperor’s hand, curious, that stopped them. His own voice, hoarse with smoke, climbed up into the box in his place:

“Everyone beneath a banner passed through the trials. Let him pass through them too. Otherwise that place is nothing but a cloth with a golden thread.”

A terrible silence fell. The Emperor looked down at him for a long moment. “Who are you?” he asked. There was no anger in his voice. There was weighing.

“A man who wants to die doing something great,” he answered. “And who has nothing to lose except that wish.” He raised his sword above his head. “Xener of Avgaria,” he shouted, his eyes on the golden banner and on the Emperor.

His name rang out at last across the arena. He had called it himself.

The echo of the name rolled a while longer through the corners of the arena. Up at the edge of the box the prince stood, his face like stone, seemingly unimpressed. Xener turned toward it. “I challenge you to a duel.”

His voice stayed hoarse with smoke, but it no longer shook. Only after that did the rest come. “Otherwise it is an insult to every fighter on this sand.”

In the box, Agam let the challenge hang, as if it did not even deserve haste. Then he shrugged.

“Fine,” a firm voice said. “If you beat me, I will give up the place. It is yours. And if not...” He sketched a smile for the first time and started down the steps of the box, in no hurry. He turned his head toward his father. “At least everyone will see why I never needed the trials.”

Up above, the Emperor said nothing. He only opened his palm, curious, the way you release a die.

Xener drew back toward the middle of the arena to make room. The rest of the fighters had pressed themselves to the walls. Agam stepped onto the sand and drew the sword at his hip. It was not yet dark: the sun had slipped behind the rim of the stands, but the light still held. Xener gripped the handle of his sword and noticed that his hands were shaking.

They stopped face to face and took each other's measure. It began.

They took a step to one side. Another. The sand creaked underfoot, and the stands went quiet row by row. Neither of them looked for an opening. Neither wanted a tactical fight: both wanted to strike the other with everything they had, ready to kill.

They moved at once. The swords slammed together, with a sound that filled the arena, and rebounded. Xener's arm went numb to the shoulder: Agam's blade was tens of times heavier than it looked.

Xener took the initiative and attacked fast. Once, twice, the combinations he had polished through every trial. Agam turned them all aside with short, almost bored movements, like a man half at play. A parry, a step, another parry. Nothing got through.

“I saw you in the arena,” Agam said between two exchanges. “You are the boy with the flames, aren’t you?” He pushed the blade aside, without effort. “What is it? Run out of fuel?”

The words landed exactly where they had been aimed. Xener thought of the scroll that had rolled shut over the unread lines, of his name left there, of the cloth with the golden thread, of the indifference in the box, and the anger came to him whole, clean, his own. His heart went warm, then hot. He screamed and let the emotion loose.

From his hands, along the steel, flames burst out. In an instant they wrapped both swords, and Agam tore himself back with one quick step, his first hurried step in the whole duel, right before the fire could catch his sleeve.

“Ahh, there it is.” Agam spun his sword and looked at the smoke rising off the edge. “So you know how to manifest your Anger. This magic suits you. You are very... fired up.”

Xener gritted his teeth and came at him again, fire and all. Agam stayed too calm, and his calm was more dangerous than any blow: between them lay a chasm of experience and power.

“But you are just an infant who has not yet learned to speak,” he said, slipping aside by half a step. “Do you want me to teach you something? At least you will die a little wiser.”

Xener wanted to fire an insult back. He did not allow himself. A cold thought slid in under the anger, thin as a draft under a door: if he pushed Agam too far, maybe Agam would use his own Anger. And who knew how the anger of a man raised in a palace burned.

That thought cost him. The flames on the sword shrank, then guttered like a candle in a draft. He looked down at his hands. "What... No. No!" he heard his own voice, desperate.

When he looked up, Agam was no longer in front of him. "You see," came the voice from behind, "you do not know how to hold your focus when your emotions change."

He turned, but too slowly. A strike from behind could be fatal. The fear was there, it had already climbed into his chest, whole. "Use the Fear and manifest. Raise a barrier behind you, a shield, anything, just to take the blow." That was all he had time to think.

The fist caught him across the jaw and carried him a good two meters through the air, until the sand received him with a scrape. Pain pulsed through his whole body. The fire went out completely, and with it, the magic. A few gasps went up through the stands.

He got up with difficulty, the taste of sand in his mouth, and set himself on guard. Agam did not bother to come after him. He stayed planted on his feet, in the middle of the arena, and waved a hand for him to come closer.

“This lesson is free. As every practitioner of magic knows, we have four base emotions: Anger, Sadness, Joy and Fear. Each manifests differently and has its own role. To keep an effect active while your emotions shift, you have to hold that feeling at the back of your mind and repeat it again and again.” A thin, cold shimmer passed along his blade, nothing like fire. “But it seems you are already reaching the limits of what you can do.”

Xener rushed in again. This time he feinted. He lit the fire on his blade and let his whole body promise a strike from above, and Agam read the sword, the way he had read every one of his moves since the first clash. Only, at the last instant, Xener shifted his weight onto the other foot, let Agam’s edge pass by his ear, and drove a foot into his stomach. In the last moments before impact, the foot burst into flame and stamped the fire into his opponent’s body.

The blow pushed Agam two steps back. A hole with scorched edges was left in his coat, and through it his skin showed, a little red. Xener’s first hit. The stands screamed and cheered. The

crowd was captivated. Xener smiled, his breath burning in his chest. "At least that: now I have probably made him angry."

But Agam was smiling. He straightened and raised his arm to the wound.

He set his palm over the burn and closed his eyes, only for a moment. A moment was all he needed to remember every guard and every servant of the palace who said, when they thought he could not hear, that he did not take after his father. That he had much to learn. That they were worried. He opened his eyes. When he took his palm away, the skin was whole. No mark, no stain, as if nothing had happened.

A quiet murmur went up. Xener looked at the smooth skin and felt his stomach tighten. He had used his Sadness to heal himself. So quickly. Some warriors spend a lifetime trying to heal a scratch the size of a fingernail through a single manifestation, and he had done it in one breath. He had the best training in the empire, and probably an affinity for Sadness, the way Xener had one for Anger. Xener clung to the only good thing in it: if his main emotion was Sadness, then his Anger could not be just as strong.

Agam waited with a grin, half turned toward the box so his father could see him. He liked to put on a show. "Maybe you

think Sadness is my specialty.” He spread his arms. “Allow me to show you who I really am.”

He raised a hand above his head and roared, and all the air in the arena stirred. The sand rose and lay back down in waves, circling him. Around his hand, out of the wind, a jagged wheel took shape, as wide as a man is tall, spinning with the hiss of a scythe. He arced his arm and loosed the projectile, straight ahead.

Xener had no time to grasp what he was seeing. “Barrier,” something screamed inside him, now, in front. Nothing came out. All he managed was to grip the sword harder. The wheel crashed into his blade with a howl, tore him off balance, bit through his guard into the flesh of his shoulder and ricocheted on, over him, straight toward the stands.

A gasp of terror, then a thud like an explosion sounded from where the wheel landed. Then, through the risen dust, a clear globe appeared, like crystal, arched over the front rows. Down at the edge of the arena, a woman with purple hair held her palm open to the sky, holding up the magic dome and shielding the onlookers.

Xener steadied himself, digging his feet deeper into the sand. The cut burned on his shoulder, the edges of his vision had melted away and he barely kept himself upright.

And Agam, for the first time since he had come down onto the sand, looked thrilled. And he did not wait a single second. He charged.

He came at him without a single pause, blow after blow, not leaving him one second to think. Xener parried on reflex, shorter and shorter, lower and lower. He tore himself back and put three steps of sand between them, and in the respite Agam deigned to grant him, he understood clearly, with a shame that hurt worse than his shoulder: there was no way he could win.

“I am ashamed,” he thought. “Is that what I feel? Wait. What do I feel? Shame is a compound emotion. I feel anger at myself, for putting myself in this on my own. Fear, of losing in front of everyone. Sadness, that I look weak. No. No, it is something deeper.”

He closed his eyes in the middle of the duel. And he was honest with himself, all the way. “Mother.”

The anger did not come from the banner. Nor from Agam. It came from here: she had died, and he had not been there to protect her. He had not been able to accept it for a single day since, and he did not accept it now either. “I was not there.”

For her there was nothing left he could do. Never, however long he lived. But the Realm was full of people who should have been

protected by their sons, and there was no one. Wherever he arrived, he would arrive in time. He would make sure of it, he told himself. He would become everyone's son if he had to.

This duty he gave himself, eyes closed, in the middle of the arena, the same way he had called his own name.

The air changed. The whole arena felt it in the same instant: the moisture vanished from everywhere at once, as if you had stepped into an oven. Cracked lips, dry eyes, hot skin.

Agam heard the stir in the stands and looked around, puzzled. Then he looked at Xener.

Xener stood hunched, head down and arms slack at his sides. And over his whole body, from the shoulders to the tips of his fingers, small flames lit, flames that did not burn him.

He breathed hard. He no longer defended himself against what he felt. He let himself feel all of it, all the way, there, in the middle of the arena, with the whole empire watching him.

"Brother, this one is insane," said Berach, from under the banners. "Oh yes," Yaleo answered, delighted. "He is one of mine."

The small flames joined together. The air between the two shimmered as it does above a fire, and every step toward Xener

felt like a forge door opened in your face. Agam gripped his sword and stopped smiling.

Xener lifted his head. It was as if a demon of fire were smiling at Agam and calling him closer, into a realm beyond, a realm of endless pain.

The creature of fire leapt. Agam managed to hide behind his sword. It did him no good. The impact blasted him across half the arena, into the far wall. He struck hard and slid down into the sand.

He got up fast, ears ringing, already searching his mind for the lessons on the magic of Fear. In his whole life he had rarely had anything to feed it with. Not now either. But when he looked toward the middle of the arena, there was no one left to defeat.

The flames died out in the sand like footprints. In the middle of them, Xener had fallen face down and did not move again.



The stands burst into deafening cheers, as if a dam had broken. It had been a fight the likes of which had never been seen in the whole Oracle's Challenge.

Agam stayed by the wall, sword in hand, and heard none of it. He looked at the heap of scorched clothes in the middle of the

sand.

“It is impossible. He had more power in that one emotion than he had ever seen in anyone. And from some country reject, no less? A nobody from a mountain village no one has heard of, capable of that?”

Agam was confused.

He turned to look toward the box, sword still in hand, braced for the stone face he knew from home. But his father was laughing. The Emperor Exeron was laughing from ear to ear, in a way Agam had not seen him laugh in years, and that laughter hurt him worse than the wall. Agam frowned.

Xener opened his eyes with sparks drifting in the air above him, and a hand the size of a shovel slid under his shoulder. Yaleo lifted him up to sitting, unhurried, the way you lift a heavy sack. “Easy, little brother,” the giant said. “You were not gone long. Just long enough to scare everyone.”

A soldier sounded a horn, and the arena settled little by little, until once more only the wind through the banners could be heard. The Emperor rose for the second time that evening. Every eye was already on him.

“I did not expect this day to give birth to such a fight,” he said. He looked at his son. Then at the boy in the sand. “I like this

kid.” He did not say it quietly.

“I hate him,” said Agam. He did not say it quietly either.

The Emperor’s laughter drew into a smile. “Then we are agreed. The ninth banner you will both carry.”

A second perfect silence fell over the arena. Agam took a step forward. “Father...”

“Half each,” the Emperor went on, over him. “The first of the two of you to become useless to the brigade will be thrown out. Not by me. You will know it yourselves. That should motivate you both.”

His smile faded completely at the end. He looked one by one at all those beneath the banners, and when he spoke again, he no longer spoke only to the two of them. “The Oracle chose you for a mission. It said that together, as a team, you can face what is coming. But nothing is guaranteed. You must do everything you can to defend the Realm.”

He sat down.

Agam passed first beneath the banner with the golden thread, his face grim and his eyes dead. Then, leaning on Yaleo’s arm, Xener passed under too. Slowly, as he had promised himself. Only, not on his own feet.

Above, the ninth banner stirred in the wind, full of grace and honor. Xener looked at the golden thread and it no longer seemed insolent to him, nor out of reach. It only seemed heavy.

He had won half a banner, a rival, and somewhere, in the future, something dreadful that he would have to face.

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